

the incoherent calls of a lone shepherd guiding his water buffaloes across the river—shifted smoothly. I spied a turquoise cupola studded on the horizon. Bearing resemblance with the dome of St Peter's Basilica in the Vatican except for the flags fluttering at the top, it grew bigger as we crept closer to the shore.

This was the Temple of Vedic Planetarium—or the slightly less of a mouthful ISKCON Mayapur, as I decided for myself. Situated close to the Hooghly's confluence with the Jalangi, the temple is a massive complex designed as an earthly interpretation of a celestial township honouring Chaitanya Mahaprabhu, the celebrated 15th century saint whose teachings formed the basis of Gaudiya Vaishnavism in the region.

We awoke early for a quick tour of the riverside village of Matiari. Brassworking is to Matiari what silk-weaving is to Murshidabad. From the moment we entered the village, the smell of melting and the endless beating of metal flooded my senses, occasionally punctuated perhaps by the aroma of mustard wafting somewhere in an alley. But the metal was everywhere: in the dusty streets, the sweltering workshops, and the little shops shimmering with freshly produced brassware. Hearing disorders and respiratory issues were merely occupational hazards here, Shubhankar confirmed to me.





WEALTH OF DETAIL
The cruise sundeck (top); the former residence of Murshidabad's Jagat Seth family (above); a Jamdani weave (right)

ONE OF THE MODERN WORLD'S FIRST COSMOPOLISES

The cruise made for Murshidabad after an excursion to Khoshbagh, the peaceful garden-cemetery on the west bank of the river where lie buried Nawab Siraj-ud-Daulah and Lutfunissa Begum, his third